

Making faces

Not all muscles pull on your bones to make you move. Controlled by signals from the brain, your facial muscles work with incredible precision, tugging on your skin to reveal what you are feeling without you even thinking about it. There are more than 7,000 different expressions, including those that last for a fraction of a second.

ALL IN THE FACE

Covering your face are thin elasticlike layers of muscle. Unlike skeletal muscles that are attached to bones, these facial muscles are attached at one end to your skull and at the other to your skin. A tiny, precise movement of one or more of these muscles pulls the skin and alters your expression.

This flat forehead muscle raises the eyebrow and wrinkles the forehead.

The circular eye muscle helps close the eyelid.

The corner of your mouth is pulled upward and outward by this cheek muscle.

The muscle surrounding the mouth brings the lips together and also helps you shape the words when you speak.

This muscle pulls the corner of the mouth outward when you smile.

The corner of the mouth is pulled downward by this lower facial muscle.

◀ **MAIN MOVERS** *Shown here are some of the main muscles that produce facial expressions, along with the actions each performs.*



FAKE OR REAL?

In the 1860s, French doctor Guillaume Duchenne (left) studied the muscles that produced facial expressions. He used small electric shocks on his patients to trigger muscle movement, resulting in a variety of expressions, in this case a smile. During his investigation, Duchenne discovered the difference between a fake and a genuine smile—the latter involving muscle movement around the eye.

